

Responsive Design

Part of **Web Development Foundations** · Estimated time: 40 min

Introduction

A responsive site rearranges itself to stay usable whether it's viewed on a phone or a wide desktop monitor. The common strategy is to design for the smallest screen first, then add complexity as space allows.

Core ideas

- Mobile-first CSS starts with simple, stacked styles for narrow screens, then uses media queries to add multi-column layouts as the viewport grows — this tends to produce simpler, more maintainable CSS than the reverse.
- A media query like `@media (min-width: 768px) { ... }` applies styles only above a given screen width, called a breakpoint.
- Relative units — %, rem, vw — scale with their context or the viewport, unlike fixed px values, which is why they're preferred for widths and font sizes in responsive layouts.
- Images should have `max-width: 100%` so they shrink to fit their container instead of overflowing it.

Example

```
.layout { display: block; }  
@media (min-width: 768px) {  
  .layout { display: flex; gap: 24px; }  
}
```

Try it yourself

Take the three-card layout from the CSS Layouts module and make it stack vertically below 600px wide, then switch to a horizontal row above that. Resize your browser window to test both states.

Further reading

- [MDN — Responsive Design](https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Learn/CSS/CSS_layout/Responsive_Design)

https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Learn/CSS/CSS_layout/Responsive_Design

- [web.dev — Learn Responsive Design](https://web.dev/learn/design/)

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